

RIM debuts BlackBerry OS 6 on flagship touchscreen BlackBerry Torch

RIM has released its answer to rising smartphone competitors, the iPhone and the Android platform, in a brand new device known as the Torch. It is a 3G-capable multi-touch slider with a better multimedia and social-networking capabilities in a "visual, fluid interface". The Torch also happens to be the elusive BlackBerry 9800 Bold that had been spotted on numerous occasions.

"Following extensive research and development to address consumer needs and wants, we are delivering a communications, browsing and multimedia experience that we think users will love, and we are thrilled to debut BlackBerry 6 OS on the amazing new BlackBerry Torch smartphone." A RIM spokesman commented on the



phone's release. It is releasing exclusively on AT&T.

The BlackBerry Torch's specifications include: 624MHz Marvell processor; slider-QWERTY,

3.2-inch multi-touch capacitive touchscreen with a 480x360 resolution, 5MP camera, 512 MB RAM, 512 MB ROM, 4GB internal storage, expandable storage up to 32GB and a 1300 mAh battery that offers 5.5 hours of talk time and 432 hours of standby time.

The new BlackBerry 6 OS will bring universal search, better multimedia capabilities including Wi-Fi Music Sync, new camera modes, a new podcasts application, WebKit-based HTML5 supporting browser, and social network/instant messaging unified inbox features to BlackBerry.

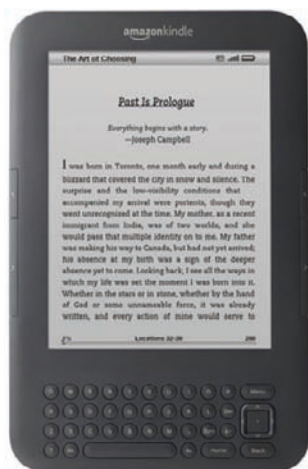
RIM has also announced which current models will receive upgrades, "subject to carrier certifications in the months ahead": Pearl 3G, Bold 9650, and Bold 9700.

As an all-out business phone,

it wouldn't be fair to compare the BlackBerry Torch to an iPhone 4 or any modern Android device, but if one did, the most obvious disadvantage the Torch has is the lack of apps/games in BlackBerry App World, which are available in their thousands at the Android Market and Apple App Store.

Another disadvantage in the sphere of multimedia and apps is the lack of internal memory and a substantial battery life. The lack of a front-facing camera is questionable, as is the lack of HDMI output, though the phone does play quite a few video formats, such as MP4, WMV, H.263 and H.264.

RIM has taken the more difficult path, competing against established players in the media and apps world. Last heard, it knocked off \$100 off its retail price due to low sales. **d**



If a price drop from \$259 to \$189 was not enough to convince you to buy the new 3G+Wi-Fi 6-inch Kindle, maybe this news might.

Amazon launches cheaper Wi-Fi-only Kindle 3, for \$139

Amazon has released a Wi-Fi-only version of the 6-inch Kindle, which costs a whole \$50 less, at \$139. In some places (read India), 3G option won't make much of a difference, not for a while now.

This move, like the first massive price drop, is in obvious response to new e-reader products being introduced by Amazon's competition, very specifically Barnes & Nobles' just released Wi-Fi only Nook,

which is priced at \$149. Amazon is definitely trying to keep a price advantage here, also pricing its 3G+Wi-Fi version for \$10 less than the \$199 3G Nook. It will release on August 27th in the US and UK.

Amazon also revealed that the Kindle will be available in white and graphite colours. You might be wondering how Kindle 3 is better than its predecessor, the Kindle 2. Well, it has a better contrast e-ink technology, twice

the storage at 4GB (now capable of storing 3,500 books), and, it is 17 per cent lighter, 20 per cent faster, and 21 per cent thinner.

Jeff Bezos, Amazon's CEO, made it quite clear that Apple iPad was not the Kindle's direct competition. Kindle's main focus is to deliver high quality e-text.

"It is distracting rather than enhancing. You are not going to improve Hemingway by adding video snippets," he said in one interview. **d**